

## UTT Chapter 11 Assignment

Hello there!

Well, school has started back, and today is the first day. I am really going to miss sleeping in every day! It is nice to get back to a routine though: up at 8:30 a.m., grab a cup of coffee (or three), and run to catch the bus. It is awesome getting to see Sarah and the gang again. We are probably going to meet up for coffee this week to finally decide on a book. I'll let you know if we actually pick something!

I've seen a lot of flyers up around campus advertising different clubs and organizations to get involved in throughout the semester. Did you know we have a sky diving club and a scuba club? It is pretty awesome. Apparently student government elections are going to be held at the end of the semester. It might be neat to run for office! Obviously, I wouldn't be able to be president or anything like that, but maybe I could be a senator. Getting involved with major decisions affecting the campus would be an amazing opportunity. Who knows? I might even decide to be a political science major. Politics could use some Christian involvement, huh?

My class schedule is pretty great this semester. I am taking Intro to Psychology, Political Theory 101, History of Western Civilization, biology, and macro-economics. Right now, I am really jazzed about biology. The professor is cool, but she actually lectured and assigned us homework for the first day of class. She began talking about evolution and how it is responsible for producing everything we see around us. It was weird to hear her call humans just another animal. She said that anyone who believes differently is ignoring the scientific evidence; evolution is a fact, and she will not teach "religious views" in her class. I know that, as Christians, we believe that God created us after his image, which separates us from the animals. Yet my professor claims that evolution is undeniably true and everything else is merely religion.

Maybe you can help me! Sarah didn't seem to be affected by what the professor said. In fact, Sarah seemed to agree with her wholeheartedly. **What do Secularists believe about the theory of evolution?** I asked Mark what he thought since he usually seems to agree with Sarah. He said something about the traditional theory of evolution operating too slowly. I'm not completely sure how else it could work.

**What do Marxists believe about the theory of evolution?** I also asked Nathan what he thought since he believes everything is divine. He began to talk about evolution in a "spiritual" sense instead of a biological one. Given Nathan's theology, I guess this makes sense. Then again, I'm still a bit fuzzy on the concept. **How does New Spirituality view evolution?** Finally, if evolution is treated as an undeniable fact, **why is it important for Christians to focus on origins?**

Good thing you are in a worldview class! I wish I had taken one while I was in high school. Maybe then I wouldn't have all these questions in college! Anyway, I hope you are doing well. It was great seeing you over Christmas. Hopefully we can hang out over spring break!

See you later!

-Doug

*Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:*

### **1. What do Secularists believe about the theory of evolution?**

Secularism adheres to a **neo-Darwinian** theory of evolution. This theory expands upon Darwin's original notion by proposing that natural selection works upon beneficial genetic mutations that randomly occur within organisms. In other words, small "glitches" within DNA occasionally produce beneficial traits that natural selection favors. This was a response to Darwin's lack of explanation for how beneficial traits came about in the first place. This new version of Darwinism gives Secularism the best *naturalistic* explanation for the origins of the universe and the diversity of life within. If mankind is the result of a purposeless and natural process that had no direction or plan, then evolution expels the need for a supernatural Creator. [11.3]

### **2. What do Marxists believe about the theory of evolution?**

Marxism is built upon the idea that God doesn't exist and the universe is composed solely of matter. Darwin's theory made both materialism and atheism plausible. However, evolution wasn't just a biological theory for Marxism. Marx used Darwinism to justify his own views of human society. According to Marx, if biological life inevitably evolves, then sociological life must inevitably progress as well. Species are growing more and more complex through the process of evolution, and society is progressing toward communism.

As Marxism sees it, the main problem with Darwin's theory is that the dialectic predicts a *rapid* development of a new synthesis. This idea runs contradictory to the gradual changes described by Darwin. To overcome this setback, contemporary Marxists have adopted the theory of **punctuated equilibrium**—the belief that evolutionary changes occur over relatively quick periods of time, followed by periods of time with little or no evolutionary change. [11.4]

### **3. How does New Spirituality view evolution?**

Most New Spiritualists would affirm a belief in biological evolution. However, New Spirituality is not ultimately concerned with biological changes. For New Spirituality, Darwinian evolution merely provides a starting point for form of cosmic evolution. Since everything is ultimately interconnected divine energy, New Spirituality proposes **spiritual evolution**—the belief that humanity is continually progressing toward higher consciousness. As each of us learns to accept to our own divinity, we evolve in consciousness. Unlike Darwin's gradual theory of biological evolution, many new agers believe that spiritual evolution can occur much more rapidly. Some propose that after enough of humanity has achieved higher consciousness, a tipping

point will be reached and others will be absorbed. In this new age, humanity will be at one with itself in collective consciousness. [11.6]

#### **4. Why is it important for Christians to focus on origins?**

The field of biology—and especially the origin of life—is highly relevant, even integral, to the understanding of our faith. How life arose and who, if anyone, made it happen, are the ground-zero questions in the battle for all other ideas. It is important to demonstrate that God-as-designer is not an unreasonable position for either science or faith, certainly not any more unreasonable than ignoring design and believing in spontaneous generation. [11.8]